



**Mother and baby homes (including
pre-1948 Workhouses) and
Magdalene laundries oral history
project**

Interview with FX

Anonymous (FX)

26th March 2019

Location: Queen's University Belfast

Interviewed by Olivia Dee

Transcribed by Jack Crangle

FX was interviewed at Queen's to offer her testimony about her search for her birthmother who entered Hopedene mother and baby institution when she discovered that she was pregnant with FX, at the age of 21. FX was adopted in a process organised by the Church of Ireland Adoption Society. FX's birthmother was from a Protestant family in a rural part of the Republic of Ireland but was working in Northern Ireland in the 1970s. FX explained the social stigma that would have been attached to her birthmother if she had taken her baby back to her rural community. Moreover, her relationship with her baby's father was not a secure one. FX managed to trace her birthmother when she was 19 and they have established a good relationship. However, she has only agreed to talk with FX about her time in Hopedene on one occasion and, then, only briefly. FX's understanding is that her birth mother did not have a negative experience in Hopedene and compared it favourably with what she has read about other mother and baby institutions as well as Magdalene laundries. However, in terms of her own search for her origins, FX was frustrated by aspects of the bureaucracy and the lack of records that were made available to her.

We have redacted names, dates and locations to maximise the anonymity of FX, her birthmother and others. Redactions are indicated by **

OD: Okay. Alright, so just for the tape, we're here in my office. My name is Olivia Dee, we're here in my office in Queen's, and I'm here with an

interviewee who is going to tell me a little bit about her mother's experience with Hopedene. And it is the 26th of March 2019. Alright, so these are now recording and I've tested them, so they work. So just before we switched on the tapes you showed me some documents that you have, and that included a photograph of you at four and a half months that was taken in the home of one of the women who ran Hopedene?

FX: Yes, one of the women who worked in Hopedene.

OD: Worked in Hopedene, great. And then you also have the statement, I guess we would call it a statement of intention, or a notice, oh, notice of intention, which is the social worker Mrs, or Miss *name redacted* from the Church of Ireland Adoption Society, who was given notice of intention that your birth parents can then adopt you.

FX: Yes.

OD: And also, we have – which is also interesting, I know you weren't sure – but we have a note from a solicitor charging forty pounds, which is the, kind of, fee around organising the adoption or...

FX: Well yes, and the paperwork, because obviously you need a new birth certificate, the legal side of that.

OD: Thank you. And we also have some other information about your father's, your birth father's birth certificate and some letters that he wrote to your mother.

FX: Yes.

OD: So we've sort of looked through those already. So now I just wanted to ask you a couple of questions like we discussed. So the first one is, can you just tell me, first of all, what you know about why your mother went to Hopedene, why she ended up in Hopedene, any information you have around that?

FX: Okay, so my mother was from a very small village in County *redacted*, from a, I suppose you would call a god fearing farming family. And she came up to *location redacted* to train for *occupation redacted*, and at some point at that time she met my father. She was dating him, he was *occupation redacted* and she was dating him for eleven months. And she became pregnant with me. It was 197*, so as you can imagine there was a lot of stigma at that time, and she really didn't feel that it was practical, or best for me or her, for her to keep me. She just couldn't see a way that, that that could happen, and the relationship with my father was unstable.

OD: Yep.

FX: And he also was at a point in his life where, I don't know if it was true, but he told her at the time that it would affect his job, it would affect his life in a major way too, so.

OD: So she didn't have support from anywhere, really.

FX: Well she made a lot of the decis-, she wasn't, she wasn't in any way forced to give me up for adoption.

OD: Good.

FX: I think, probably, given the option, she wouldn't have told her parents that she was pregnant.

OD: Right.

FX: So she went to the Church of Ireland Adoption Society, which is in Talbot Street in Belfast, and because she was Church of Ireland, and I guess for a young girl they went to, she needed help and she went to what she knew. And she stayed, she then stayed from, I'm not sure how long before I was born, but several weeks before I was born, she stayed in Hopedene.

OD: Right.

FX: And then she had me in the *name of hospital redacted*, and she went back to Hopedene and she stayed there with me for, I think, about three weeks. And then she had to go to *city in GB redacted* because she was starting her *nature of training course redacted* and after that point she left me there, and she came back twice to visit me before I was adopted.

OD: Yeah so you said one of the, the picture that you had taken was one of the times that she came back to visit you, and that the woman from Hopedene had taken them out to her home, almost, you said, to show her...

FX: Yeah, so I was four and a half months in the photo, and I was actually, I think, yeah, so I was adopted in March, I think it was there, so I think this must've been, I don't know, January or so. She'd come back to visit me, and she always said that the ladies who worked in the home, who I presume looked after me, she always said that they were really lovely and very kind ladies. And one of these ladies – whose name she can't, she couldn't remember – took her

and I to her house for the day, and that we had a lovely day at her house, but I think the, the lady's intention was that she would just see how nice it was being with me, and we'd have a lovely time, and she would change her mind and decide to keep me at that point.

OD: Okay. And so, was there kind of an open-ended aspect to it, that they would keep you as long as your mother was unsure? Or ... 'cause four months is quite a long time.

FX: No she had, yeah she had decided to give me up for adoption fairly early on actually. Whenever she left for *location redacted* after a few weeks, that she had actually made that decision.

OD: Right, okay.

FX: And *detail redacted* ...[laughs]

OD: I don't know that I would have noticed.

FX: Yeah, there's a thing that they look for in babies *detail redacted*.

OD: Yeah, and you had them?

FX: And I, and that's one of the signs. And because of that they obviously couldn't put me up for adoption until they knew for definite.

OD: Right.

FX: Whether I had or not. She did tell me that her mother and her brother came to visit me once, in Hopedene, and the cloud was still hanging over at that point about whether I did have *detail redacted*. And at that point, her mother said “well, we’ll just have to bring her home and deal with it”.

OD: Oh gosh, wow. And, and they weren’t, was your maternal, it would be your grandmother, was she interested in bringing you home anyway?

FX: I think my birth mother didn’t really give anybody a choice. I think I’m a bit like her in that I’ll make the decision and then tell people afterwards.

OD: Right.

FX: You know, I think she didn’t want them involved in the decision making process.

OD: Yeah.

FX: She had made that decision already. From what I have heard about her mother and father, I think they would have brought me home. But it would have been difficult because they were old.

OD: Right.

FX: So it wouldn’t have been an ideal situation.

OD: Yeah.

FX: Plus it was a very, very, small town, and there would've been a lot of scandal around it.

OD: I can imagine. It's, I just think it's very, the four month period is, I know there was a reason, but it's so long, and you just think it must've made things quite difficult, and it must've been a hard decision for your mother even if she had made it quite early on.

FX: Awk yes I think, you know, I think it definitely was.

OD: To keep coming back as well, and the picture is lovely. So your mother goes to *city redacted and course redacted* and where do you go? To your birth parents? Sorry, your adopted parents?

FX: Yes.

OD: Yeah.

FX: So this was the, the date of handover in March, I don't know what date. So that was the, that was the date of handover, what was that again?

OD: *day redacted* of March.

FX: The *day redacted* of March. So I was born *date redacted*. So that's, what, September, October, November, December, January, February.

OD: Sounds about six months.

FX: Six months, yeah.

OD: Wow.

FX: When I was adopted. It's quite funny, because before I had my own children I, I didn't really know what a six month baby was like. I kind of thought six months is a babe in arms, and then you kind of know children, you realise that, six months old, they're actually, you know there's a lot has gone on before that period.

OD: Yeah. And so what did your, do you know anything about the circumstances of adoption? Did it, you know, why were they adopting?

FX: Why they adopted?

OD: Yeah.

FX: Yes. My parents had had a baby; well, they'd had difficulty getting pregnant, and then they had had a little girl, and they didn't know until she was born that she had *identifying detail redacted*. And she lived for, I think, four days, and they knew that she was going to die any, at any point. So she died, and then after that my mum couldn't, my birth, my adopted mum couldn't have any more children.

OD: Okay.

FX: So, my adopted mum had a lot of health issues, and she had health issues all through my life and still has health issues. And we had a family doctor, as you did in those days, who had been your family doctor through the

generations, and he actually – I maybe shouldn't tell you this – he actually lied about her health.

OD: Right.

FX: Because otherwise she wouldn't have been able to adopt me.

OD: Oh okay, oh no I'm sure that's fine now.

FX: Yeah.

OD: Yeah, so did the doctor have any connection to Hopedene at all, or did he just happen to...?

FX: No. It was just a thing that you needed.

OD: Okay.

FX: I think it was very different then when you were wanting to adopt a baby, I think the criteria was very different. And one of the things was that you had a good clean bill of health.

OD: That's bizarre, okay.

FX: Yeah there was really, really strange things and they, you know, they did have a – it was two years after their baby died that they got me. I'm not sure how long they were going through the process.

OD: And so they went to Hopedene because they were Church of Ireland?

FX: They went, well they went to Church of Ireland.

OD: Yeah okay.

FX: Because they, yeah they were Church of Ireland, so it was suggested to them through the church that they went to the Church of Ireland Adoption Agency. And then they were linked up with Miss *name redacted*.

OD: Yeah.

FX: The social worker. I actually have, somewhere, letters that were passed between her and my par-, my adopted parents, and between her and my birth mother.

OD: Right.

FX: Just going, letters going back and forth about what was...

OD: [Interrupts] Oh, okay so there was no connection between your adopted parents and your birth mother? They didn't write directly, so they went through the social worker?

FX: They went through her, yeah, it was a completely closed adoption, so they knew very little about her, and she knew nothing about them.

OD: Wow. And you said, before we switched the tape on, you said you had been in contact, in that sort of way. You've got a lot of this information from, is through the contact with your birth mother.

FX: Yes.

OD: That you managed when you were nineteen?

FX: Yes.

OD: Yeah. Which, as I said, was quite amazing, because it usually takes, I don't know, sometimes it takes a lot longer or it's, yeah, so.

FX: Yeah I don't know. I think it's just something that I, I always wanted to do. I had, kind of, a, a difficult childhood and a difficult teenage years, and I guess at that time in my life I thought this is what'll, this is the thing, this is the missing thing.

OD: Yeah. And did you know you were adopted?

FX: Always, yeah. I don't actually remember being sat down and told I was adopted, but it was always just, it was always just a thing, and my dad in particular would've always made it, you know, that we chose you. My dad's dead two years now, but he had quite an active imagination. In some ways it was bad because he made up stories that I then believed for such a long time until I got older and realised that can't possibly...

OD: Yeah.

FX: ...be true.

OD: But he tried to make it more magical?

FX: He tried to make it all, yeah, he tried to make it all magic. He told me that they went to the mother and baby home, which they never were, and that he chose me out of all the babies because I smiled at him.

OD: Aw.

FX: You know, it was just such a lovely story.

OD: Dads.

FX: But also, in some ways, a cruel story, because you kind of think, as a child, you nearly start thinking, I remember that.

OD: Yeah definitely. I think that's a really common thing, that dads can do.

FX: It gives you fake memories.

OD: Yeah. So you said they never went to the mother and baby home, so it was picked through the Church of Ireland?

FX: It was all through there. They just, they knew that that's where I had been, but it was all through the Church of Ireland. An interesting thing, their only kind of connection with it was that my, my name, my birth name is *redacted* and I don't know, obviously, who was looking after me for those six months, but my mum and dad told me that there was a lady who worked there who had called me *redacted*, as a kind of a little nickname.

OD: Yeah

FX: And then when my parents got me, they named me – on my birth certificate – *redacted*, which is after my adopted mum, but they called me *redacted*, because that's what she had called me. And I don't know how they got that information. I don't even know if it's true. But I can't think it's not true because I can't think where they would have got that name from.

OD: No, no, it sounds, sounds true.

FX: Yeah, and they continued, and that's my name to this day.

OD: That's nice.

FX: So it's just so lovely and, kind of, a bit strange that my name that I'm called every day I was called by someone that I don't know.

OD: And it's really, I suppose it must be hard to not know, because you said, obviously, this picture was taken in a woman's house, and she clearly showed a lot of kindness to your mother.

FX: Yeah.

OD: And it's sad that we don't know who they are.

FX: It is, it is, it'd be lovely to know, just.

OD: But that's, sort of...

FX: Even my first Christmas, I must have spent my first Christmas...

OD: Yeah.

FX: ...there.

OD: So this is Hopedene around 197*. So, it would be interesting to know who those were. Okay. So you said, so you've picked up a lot of this, clearly, through your birth mother, and also, I'm assuming you got things like the birth certificate through, just public records and things. So what does your mother tell you about Hopedene, if anything? Because I know it can be difficult.

FX: To be honest, not very much. She said that, when she was there, it was obviously a difficult time for her, but that the place was fine.

OD: Good.

FX: And that she was with other girls who were in a, my mother was twenty-one, so she wouldn't have been the youngest.

OD: Twenty-one?

FX: Mm-hmm.

OD: Interesting, okay.

FX: So there were other girls there who were in a similar position. So obviously it wasn't a, a great place to be, just because, I don't know whether those other girls were keeping their babies, or whether they were just there for a period of time.

OD: And did she have anything that she had to do while she was there? Was it, was it sort of monitored, or was it just more like a hostel where you could come and go, or...?

FX: I honestly don't know.

OD: Okay.

FX: She said there were people who, who talked to her. I don't know if they were social workers. But there were people that would have talked to her and talked through her options. And at no point, you know, she's very clear, at no point was she forced or did she feel under pressure.

OD: Yeah.

FX: She, she told me about a minister who came in from a local church. A young minister who used to come in and play with the babies, and just that he was really nice and, you know, that he would've thrown me up in the air and I'd have laughed, and things like that. So there, there must have been some kind of connection there.

OD: Yeah, definitely.

FX: Maybe it was the local Church of Ireland, or whatever, that they, minister would have come in.

OD: And were you, were you christened?

FX: Not by her.

OD: Okay. But that was something that your adopted parents did?

FX: Yes.

OD: Okay. 'Cause, it's interesting because, I think what's interesting about your story is the length of time. So, I was just wondering whether that was done before or... Okay, and your mother, now that you kind of know her and you have, kind of, met and things like that, does she seem to have any kind of feelings about what, what these mother and baby homes were like in general and what, like, now that people are doing enquiries in the south and that we're doing this research, does she ever, kind of, talk about that?

FX: Do you know, any time I've had a conversation with her it's me that's made the conversation happen. And even the conversation where I, I would, I put her on the spot and asked her about my father. She made it very clear at the end of that conversation that "I'm going to tell you this stuff, and then I don't want to discuss it again". So there's things I can't even go back, you know, that I might want clarified or...

OD: Yeah.

FX: But my, my aunt – her sister – who is a few years younger than her ...she, she has talked to me a lot more. And she said, at the time, that she didn't really think very much about it because she was a young girl.

OD: Yeah.

FX: But as time went on, she felt very robbed that she had lost her niece.

OD: Yeah.

FX: But that her sister wouldn't talk to her about it. But she told me that they are, she's religious, and she told me that she had always prayed that I would be safe, and when she had seen – her sister moved away from Ireland and just through the seventies and eighties I guess – when she saw things happening in Northern Ireland and knew I was there, that she always prayed that I was okay. And also, she said that when she saw the things about mother and baby homes, you know, she wondered, and it made her think, you know, I hope...

OD: That you were okay.

FX: ... was okay, and was worried about, you know, and she was so relieved whenever I got in touch, 'cause she was worried about what might have, what might have happened to me.

OD: So do you have quite a good relationship with the aunt then?

FX: I probably have a better relationship with her, she's easier. I guess she's removed from it. So she's easier for me to, to talk to about it.

OD: And do your adopted parents know that you're in contact with your birth mother?

FX: Yes.

OD: Okay.

FX: They have met, they met her as well, they met her a few times, and they, actually, she was at my wedding and stuff, so...

OD: Oh okay, good.

FX: And, you know, my parents were absolutely fine.

OD: Good.

FX: I come from, look, I just seem to be surrounded by people who don't really talk about things very much, which probably isn't...[laughs]

OD: I mean I think, I think it's more common than you think, even, kind of, in families that haven't gone through this. I think, it's just getting families to talk sometimes can be so difficult.

FX: Yeah, yeah, like my adopted mum, I see her several times a week and we talk about nothing. [laughs]

OD: Okay. And so, so your adopted parents, how, sort of, old would they... well how old is your adoptive mother now?

FX: What is she? She's seventy-four.

OD: Right okay, so.

FX: So they were just a few years older.

OD: Okay. So, if I could just ask you then, just to finish, a couple of questions that I ask everyone. I was wondering what, first of all, what made you contact the, this, kind of, I suppose it's an investigation at this point, but I was just interested in what, kind of, motivated you to do that? 'Cause it's really interesting and it's really helpful for us, obviously, but...

FX: Yeah I, I had so little information myself, to go on, and I've been, I guess in the days of the internet, now, you can google things.

OD: Yeah.

FX: And I had been, for a few years now, just trying to, you know, my interest had increased, in trying to find out more. And just the realisation of where I, you know, that I spend the first six months of my life in a place that I knew nothing about. But I had googled Hopedene, and just, I just kept hitting a brick wall.

OD: Mm, because it's gone hasn't it?

FX: Yeah, it has gone, and there just doesn't seem to be any records. And even when I was, in order to get my birth certificate I had to go to, like, counselling. They wouldn't just give you the stuff, you had to go to, sort of, a counselling thing to make sure you were okay. And I asked at that point about Hopedene, and I was told that the records of when I was there had been destroyed in a fire.

OD: Okay.

FX: I don't know whether they were just telling a naïve nineteen year old that just to get rid.

OD: So this would be records of Hopedene in the early seventies?

FX: Yes. And so, when I was Googling, then I came across your inquiry, and that's where I saw there was, like, a newspaper article saying that you were collecting information.

OD: Yes, and we are, and it's really helpful. Because I think, actually, Hopedene is such a tricky place to find out about. And I've done the same thing, and actually the only thing that came up when I was looking around it was our inquiry as well.

FX: Yes.

OD: And I even, I've looked at it on several maps and things like that, and it's gone, so it's very difficult. So that's really, it's really helpful whenever we get someone who wants to tell us even just a tiny bit about Hopedene, it becomes really useful.

FX: There was something I found once, I can't remember exactly what it was, I Googled and I found something, and it had, like, numbers on it. You know, maybe numbers of mothers and babies. There was, like, a list of all the, if I find it again I will, I will send it to you.

OD: And was that, was that sort of like a count or something?

FX: A Google search. Yeah.

OD: Okay, interesting. Let me check. So who, who told you that the records had been destroyed?

FX: That would have been in the Church of Ireland Adoption Agency.

OD: Okay.

FX: So there was a guy who worked there called *redacted* somebody. Now this was quite a while ago.

OD: So this would've been when you were nineteen, so sort of late eighties?

FX: That would be, yeah.

OD: Okay.

FX: His name might have been *redacted*, but I can't remember exactly.

OD: That's okay, I can have a look. Okay.

FX: It might be worth, even, for you to, to try them, you know because...

OD: Yeah, I'm just curious.

FX: ... The Church of Ireland Adoption Society to see what they, what they have.

OD: Interesting. So we have this, the archival side of the team who will have, kind of, looked over all of this, but I just want to double check and see if

they've covered this area, because I think it would be really useful. So then the other thing is, obviously, we, we submit this to the Department of Health and they decide what to do with it. And I suppose what I ask everyone – because I want you to have a say in that – is what would you want to see come out of something like this? It sounds like your mother had, if not an easy time obviously, she at least looks back on Hopedene as being, you said, okay, fine, you know.

FX: Yeah.

OD: It was, it was, you know ... and the people were nice. So I just wondered, you know, is there anything that you would like to see come out of an inquiry as, as someone who was adopted?

FX: I don't know. I guess with these inquiries, you know, I've seen the inquiries into the Magdalene Laundry and all of that kind of thing, and it doesn't seem, from what I can see, that – the year when I was there at least – that, I can't see that there was anything bad or negative, it seemed to be supportive place for people.

OD: Yeah.

FX: For me, you know, maybe other people have different experiences, or maybe earlier on in time it might have been like that, so I guess for me it's just my own curiosity, that I would like, you know, I would love to know more about it.

OD: So things being more open, like records and stuff being more open and accessible.

FX: Yeah, absolutely yeah.

OD: Okay. Is there anything else you'd like to say while we have the tape on? Just to give you a chance if you want to.

FX: Just, you know, this is really nice for me to be able, because it's not very often that you have an opportunity in life where somebody just wants to listen to...

OD: Well we'll listen for hours, we're just interested.

FX: I could talk for hours [Laughs].

OD: Yeah.

FX: That somebody just wants to listen to your story.

OD: Yeah.

FX: And wants to ask you questions about your story. And it's not, it's not a secret in my life, but it's obviously not the kind of thing that I go around talking about all the time, you know.

OD: Yeah.

FX: So it's just nice just to have that chance, just to talk about it.

OD: Good, I'm really glad. And I'm glad that people will get to listen to it too.
Let me switch the recorders off just for a moment.

[END OF INTERVIEW]